

Vidal and Ofelia can both be considered true believers, each fully convinced of the validity of the world they have built around themselves. Vidal believes in Franco's cause and admits that he is hunting the stragglers "by choice." He is a man without doubt, just as Ofelia is without doubt when she braves the horror of the child-eating Pale Man to pass the second of the faun's tests. In *Pan's Labyrinth*, evil is just as convinced of its righteousness as good. Vidal is not a hypocrite or a coward, and charges into battle without fear. He even tells a doubting comrade that this "is the only

way to die." Ofelia shows the same conviction when attempting the faun's tasks. The sense that Vidal's bad qualities mirror Ofelia's good ones adds a complexity to events as they unfold.

Whether or not Ofelia's fantasy realm is real is left to the viewer to decide. It is also up to the audience to decide which world they believe in more: Ofelia's or Vidal's.



The film works on so many levels that it seems to change shape even as you watch it.

Stephanie Zacharek

The Village Voice

Both stories feel as textured and vivid as the other—the *Grand Guignol* set design of the Pale Man's lair is matched by the specificity of Vidal's quarters and his eerily controlled shaving routine. This is where the success of *Pan's Labyrinth* lies—not simply as a twisted fairy tale, but one that also explores the sadness of the need to escape into a fantasy world.

Although Ofelia must trust the faun as her guide to the fairy-tale world, he is a mysterious and morally ambiguous character whose ultimate motivations are hard to discern.



Guillermo del Toro Director

Guillermo del Toro was born in Guadalajara, Mexico, in 1964. His debut feature *Cronos* was released in 1992, and proved to be enough of a success for producer Harvey Weinstein to grant him a \$30 million budget to make *Mimic*, an American-set studio horror. It was also around this time that his father was kidnapped and del Toro was forced to pay a large ransom for his release. Del Toro went on to achieve Hollywood success with the *Hellboy* horror franchise, as

well as setting two movies in Franco-era Spain, *The Devil's Backbone* and *Pan's Labyrinth*, to great critical acclaim. Most recently, he directed the *kaiju*-influenced action-adventure *Pacific Rim*.

Key movies

1993 *Cronos*
2001 *The Devil's Backbone*
2004 *Hellboy*
2006 *Pan's Labyrinth*